

Ochotona princeps

American pika



Location S.W. Canada, W. USA

Length 6½–8 in (16–20 cm)
Tail None
Weight 4–6 oz (125–175 g)
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern



Found at high altitudes, this pika lives on a talus—an area of piled, broken rocks fringed by alpine meadows and low, grassy vegetation. At each talus, solitary pikas use whistling calls to defend territories that alternate across the area by gender, giving a female–male patchwork. A typical territory is 6,500 square ft (600 square m), and it has a foraging area and a den in a burrow or rock crevice.

EGG-SHAPED MAMMAL

A crouched pika has a rounded outline resembling an egg. The fur is varying shades of brown.



READY FOR WINTER



During late summer, each pika gathers a “hay pile” near its burrow that serves as food when there is snow. These hay piles contain plants with high levels of toxins that act as natural preservatives, making them last longer. Pikas eventually eat these in late winter, after the toxins have broken down.

Ochotona curzoniae

Black-lipped pika



Location E. Asia

Length 5½–8½ in (14–21 cm)
Tail None
Weight 3¼–7½ oz (90–210 g)
Social unit Group
Status Least concern



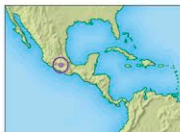
This pika is sandy brown above and dull yellow-white on the underside, with a rust-hued patch behind the ear and a dark nose and lips. An extended family

occupies each burrow system and members are sociable. In some areas this pika is so numerous as to be considered a pest. Females can have up to 5 litters of 8 young per year, which are cared for by both parents.



Romerolagus diazi

Volcano rabbit



Location C. Mexico

Length 9–14 in (23–35 cm)
Tail ¾–1¼ in (1–3 cm)
Weight 13–21 oz (375–600 g)
Social unit Group
Status Endangered

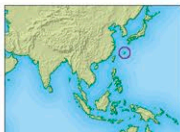


Restricted to open pine forests on volcanic peaks near Mexico City, the volcano rabbit lives in groups of 2–5. It has very short, rounded ears for a rabbit, relatively small back legs and feet, and communicates by means of penetrating whistles. Its diet is mainly the tall, dense grass in which it also makes its burrow.



Pentalagus furnessi

Amami rabbit



Location Amami and Tokuno islands (Japan)

Length 16½–20 in (42–50 cm)
Tail ¾–1½ in (1–3.5 cm)
Weight 4½–6½ lb (2–3 kg)
Social unit Individual/Group
Status Endangered



Found only on 2 small Japanese islands, this rabbit's many distinctive features include an all-black coat, pointed snout, small eyes and ears, and short, long-nailed limbs for digging nest-holes. Nocturnal in habit, it eats forest plants, such as pampas grass leaves, sweet potato runners, bamboo sprouts, nuts, and bark. Social and breeding habits are little known, although it communicates by means of clicking sounds. The female has 2 litters of 2–3 young each year.



Brachylagus idahoensis

Pygmy rabbit

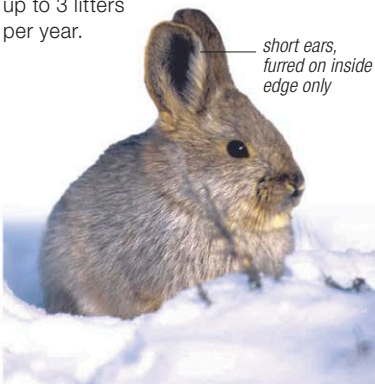


Location W. USA

Length 9–12 in (23–31 cm)
Tail ½–1 in (1.5–2.5 cm)
Weight 9–16½ oz (246–458 g)
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern



The world's smallest rabbit, this arid-adapted species digs a large burrow system and feeds on big sagebrush and closely related species. The long, silky fur on its back is gray in winter and brown in summer; the abdomen is whitish. Unlike most rabbits, it climbs well into bushes to feed, and, although solitary, it also makes pikalike whistling calls to warn neighbors of approaching predators. Breeding details are poorly known: the gestation period may be 26–28 days, and litter size 4–8, with up to 3 litters per year.



Sylvilagus aquaticus

Swamp rabbit

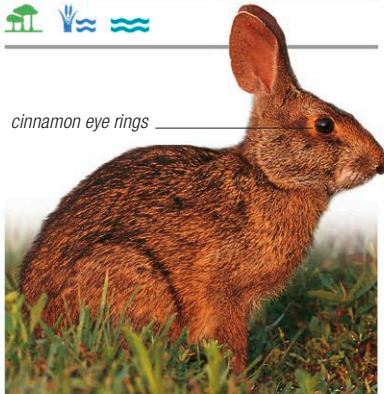


Location S.E. USA

Length 18–22 in (45–55 cm)
Tail 2–3 in (5–7.5 cm)
Weight 3½–6 lb (1.6–2.7 kg)
Social unit Group
Status Least concern



cinnamon eye rings



Always associated with water, in marshes, creeks, and pools, the swamp rabbit has black to rusty brown fur. It swims well and readily, especially if threatened, and feeds by day or night on sedges, rushes, and other aquatic plants, including swamp bamboos (*Arundinaria*). The swamp rabbit lives in small groups, usually controlled by a dominant territorial male, and builds an above-ground nest of plant stalks and stems. The female lines the breeding nest with her fur, in the typical rabbit manner. The average litter size is 3.

Sylvilagus floridanus

Eastern cottontail



Location Central America to N. South America

Length 11¼–18¼ in (30–48 cm)
Tail 1–2½ in (2.5–6.6 cm)
Weight 1¼–3¼ lb (0.8–1.5 kg)
Social unit Group
Status Least concern



Widely distributed in many habitats over its natural range, and introduced to new areas of North America and Europe, the cottontail has the typical

rabbit body form with a reddish-topped white tail. In summer, it feeds on lush green vegetation; bark and twigs predominate in winter. Groups have established dominance hierarchies. Average litter size ranges from 5 in North America to 2 in South America.

